

Agent of chaos: Paddy Pimblett's (facing page) greatest asset in his matchup against Justin Gaethje is his ability to weaponise chaos. He thrives in scrambles that occur between striking ranges.

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shifts significantly if the fight hits the canvas, which represents Pimblett's clearest path to victory. While Gaethje possesses an elite wrestling pedigree, he has shown vulnerability to back-takes (a grappling transition to gain dominant control from the back) and high-level Brazilian jiu-jitsu transitions in past championship bouts.

Pimblett's greatest asset in this matchup is his ability to weaponise chaos. He thrives in scrambles that occur between striking ranges. For Pimblett to secure the upset, he must bait Gaethje into a clinch or a poorly timed takedown attempt, using his reach to attack the neck or transition to the back before the 'Human Highlight' can reset his stance.

This theme of grappling versus striking continues into the co-main event, where Kayla Harrison defends her bantamweight title against the returning Amanda Nunes.

Harrison will look to impose positional control, using her judo to chain clinches into takedowns, pinning Nunes and applying sustained top pressure. Her success hinges on safely closing the distance to avoid Nunes' famed counters.

Nunes, meanwhile, must rely on footwork and a sharp jab to manage distance, forcing Harrison to work while exposing her limited experience off her back. Whether Nunes can shake off ring rust and exploit those gaps against the division's most dominant grappler forms the night's most intriguing tactical dilemma.

Familiar foes

At UFC 325, featherweight supremacy takes centre stage as reigning champion Alexander Volkanovski defends his title in a



Familiar foes: Alexander Volkanovski (left) will aim to deploy his unmatched cage IQ and leg-kick conditioning to stifle Diego Lopes (right), who seeks to address the technical gaps that allowed Volkanovski to outpoint him in their previous encounter in Miami.

high-stakes rematch against Diego Lopes.

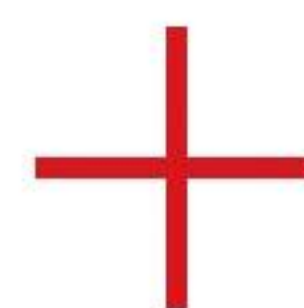
Their first encounter at UFC 314 was a gruelling tactical battle that saw Volkanovski reclaim the throne via unanimous decision, though not without peril. Lopes demonstrated his ability to hurt the champion with raw power and chaotic flurries.

Returning to home soil in Sydney, Volkanovski will aim to deploy his unmatched cage IQ and leg-kick conditioning to stifle the challenger, while Lopes seeks to address the technical gaps that allowed the champion to outpoint him in the later rounds of their Miami war.

The co-main event serves as a critical juncture for the lightweight division, as New Zealand's Dan Hooker faces the 'God of War' Benoit Saint Denis.

Hooker, a veteran known for his devastating knees, is looking to rebound from a recent setback against Arman Tsarukyan and

reclaim his status as the division's premier gatekeeper. He faces a surging Saint Denis, whose specialised grappling and Special Forces-honed aggression embody a kill-or-be-killed style that has seen him finish his last three opponents, most recently via a first-round knockout.



Did you know?

In 2018, Nunes made history by knocking out Cris Cyborg in just 51 seconds. The victory did more than earn her a second belt. It made her the first woman in UFC history to hold titles in two weight classes simultaneously. She remains the only fighter, male or female, to successfully defend two titles while holding them at the same time.